the common good. Communitarianism supports a State that is democratically elected and constituted. They strongly aspire for a State that is responsible and responsive to demands of the community.

Concept of Rights

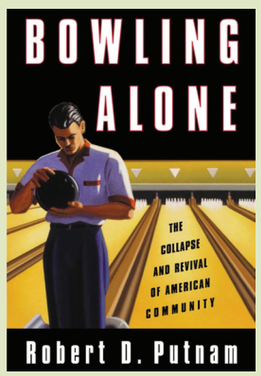
Communitarianism believes that rights and responsibilities are intimately related. It rejects the excessive reliance of libertarianism on the concept of individual autonomy and rights. Instead, it focuses on a new concept of rights where common good is given importance. They strongly contend that the common good of the community has supremacy and priority over the rights of the individuals as it is prior to them. Every person may have his own conception of good but such individual good must be subordinated to the idea of common good. A new concept of positive rights is propagated where in a wide variety of rights like State-subsidised education, State-subsidized housing, safe environment, universal healthcare are demanded for the community members. A synthesis between rights and responsibilities is advocated by certain thinkers who belong to Responsive Communitarianism.

Concept of Justice

Communitarians attack John Rawls and other libertarian thinkers on the concept of justice. They reject universalism of libertarianism, their argument that the concept of justice is universally applicable as it is based on reason. On the contrary, communitarians articulate the particularistic view of justice. Every community develops its own notions of justice and therefore it differs from society to society.

Therefore, we can conclude that Communitarianism as a political doctrine believes in the indispensability of community for the development of the 'situated and embedded man'. The positive State should concentrate on the provision of positive rights to community and its people so that common good can be preserved and promoted. But Libertarianism still criticises Communitarianism as preparing the path for the emergence of collectivism and authoritarianism.

DO YOU KNOW?



Robert D.Putnam played a crucial role in the emergence of communitarianism. He analysed the game of Bowling in America. In his analysis he found that in the earlier days, a large number of Americans played the game. They built social networks, knowledge and skills (Social Capital) by constantly interacting with other people in the community while playing the game. But gradually people lost interest in the game with the arrival of new forces and facilities like television, internet, etc. As people spent more time in their technology-driven gadgets, their social interaction with other members came down leading to erosion of social capital. Ultimately, the quality of democracy also suffered as people have limited social interactions and public engagement. The political apathy of people eroded the strength of democracy.

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